Invariable Adjectives

Adjectifs invariables

Most French adjectives have to agree with their nouns in gender and number, but there are many exceptions, known as invariable adjectives. These have just one unchanging form no matter the gender and number of the noun they modify.

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Par exemple...

la région nord	the northern region
des lois antitabac	anti-smoking laws

Most invariable adjectives fit in one of the following groups:

Apocopes	*extra, perso, sympa*
Cardinal directions	*nord, sud, est, ouest*
Color adjectives*	*argent, chocolat, orange*
Foreign adjectives	*cool, lambda, people*
Numerical adjectives*	*deux, troisième, quatrième*

* Not all of these kinds of adjectives are invariable; see the lessons for more detailed info.

Cross-dressing adjectives

When words that normally belong to another part of speech are used as adjectives, they are invariable: Non-adjectives.

Likewise, adjectives that are used as adverbs are invariable: Adjectives as adverbs.

Other invariable adjectives

There are also invariable adjectives that don't fit into any of the above categories:

antiblocage	antilock (brakes)
antibruit	soundproof, noise-reducing

anticalcaire		water softening
anticellulite		anti-cellulite
anticorrosion		anticorrosive
antidouleur		painkilling
antiglisse		nonslip
antihausse		anti-inflation
antipersonnel		antipersonnel
antrirejet		anti-rejection (drugs)
antirides		anti-wrinkle
antitabac		anti-smoking
arsénieux		arsenic
autofocus		autofocus
autoreverse		auto reverse
chaque		each
cracra	(familiar)	dirty, scuzzy, grotty
craignos	(familiar)	shady, dodgy
craspec	(familar)	shabby, grotty
dextrorsum		dextrorsal, clockwise
furax	(informal)	furious
gnangnan	(informal)	silly, soppy
manganeux		manganous
mercureux		mercurous
multiplex		multiplex
omnibus		omnibus, local
péritel		multisocket
plusieurs		several
princeps		first (edition)
raplapla	(informal)	exhausted, flat

redox		redox
rikiki *riquiqui*	(informal)	tiny, stingy
rosat		made from roses
sélénieux		selenious
sénestrorsum		sinistrorse, counter-clockwise
soi-disant		so-called, supposedly
surchoix		prime, top-quality
toc toc		crazy, nutty
tout craché		very similar, spitting image
tricourant		three-phase (electricity)

C'est

With *c'est* plus an adjective on its own, including in impersonal expressions, the adjective is always invariable.

Par exemple...

La maison, c'est joli.	The house is pretty.
C'est intéressant, la chimie.	Chemistry is difficult.

* As opposed to *c'est une jolie maison* and *la chimie est intéressante*.

Related lessons

- Adjectives
- Agreement
- Directions
- Indefinite adjectives

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